PRE-PURCHASE INSPECTION CHECKLIST

Toyota 4Runner 1st Gen

1984–1989 · N60

BOXYTRUCKS

CHECK BEFORE YOU BUY

- [ ] **Rust, everywhere**
  Forum owners point to the frame ahead of the rear spring perches, the rear quarters and wheel wells, the left rear near the exhaust exit, and, on sunroof-equipped trucks, A-pillars that owners say rotted from blocked drains. Hagerty warns that floors and quarter panels aren't reproduced, so a rusty body is a fabrication job, not a parts order.

- [ ] **Know which axle you're buying**
  1984–85 trucks have the solid front axle; 1986–89 have IFS. Solid-axle trucks carry a price premium and some sellers stretch the truth, so look underneath: leaf springs and manual hubs up front mean solid axle; torsion bars and CV axles mean IFS.

- [ ] **22R-E timing chain guides**
  The plastic timing-chain guides are a known breakage item — LC Engineering makes metal-backed replacements specifically for it. A cold-start rattle from the front of the engine, or no record of the job, means budget for chain, guides and tensioner.

- [ ] **V6 head gaskets**
  The 1988–89 3VZ-E shares the V6's head-gasket reputation. Toyota's October 1996 policy adjustment (1988–94 V6 trucks) is long expired and the later V06 campaign only covered 1/90–10/94 builds, so check for coolant loss, overheating history and white exhaust, and ask for paperwork on any head work.

- [ ] **Sagging rear and tired suspension**
  Rear leafs sag on nearly all of them. Feathered front tyres can mean worn front-end parts or a bad alignment; on IFS trucks check idler arm and tie-rod play.

- [ ] **Top, glass and seals**
  Removable tops and ageing seals leak; a tarp over the roof in the ad is a clue. Check the power tailgate window works — IH8MUD members flag it as a weak point on both early generations.

- [ ] **Interior parts**
  Carpets can be found, but Hagerty says reproduction seats and upholstery generally can't, and owners say good seats are especially scarce. An intact original interior is worth paying for.

- [ ] **Rear seats and belts**
  Many 1984–86 base trucks came without a rear seat, and Toyota never fitted rear shoulder belts. If you plan to carry kids, factor that in.

YEARS TO KNOW

1985	SWEET SPOT	Fuel-injected 22R-E (116 hp) arrives; rear seat available on all trims. Last year of the solid front axle, which Hagerty says purists still seek out; an Expedition Portal member rates carbureted trucks less desirable

1988–89 (V6)	BEWARE	3.0 3VZ-E V6 trucks: a Hagerty expert says most enthusiasts avoid the six and choose the four, and the 3VZ-E's head-gasket history starts here

RECALLS TO ASK ABOUT

- ☐ **Fuel hose too close to EGR pipe**
  1988 · NHTSA 88V-019
- ☐ **Steering relay rod fatigue crack**
  1989 (campaign covers 1989–1995 4Runner) · NHTSA 05V-389

IS IT THE REAL THING?

- ☐ **Solid axle or IFS**
  1984–85 trucks have a solid front axle on leaf springs; 1986–89 have independent front suspension with a 3 in wider track. Look under the front: a beam axle and leaf packs vs torsion bars and CV shafts.
- ☐ **Engine by year**
  1984½ is carbureted 22R only; EFI 22R-E from 1985; the 22R-TE turbo only for 1986–87, mostly with the automatic; the 3VZ-E V6 for 1988–89 on SR5.
- ☐ **Rear seat and trim**
  Many 1984–86 trucks came in without a rear seat (base DX omitted it), partly to classify them as trucks for import duty. The SR5 package added gauges, better trim and the rear seat.
- ☐ **Hilux Surf twins**
  Japan's Hilux Surf used 3Y petrol and 2L / 2L-T diesel engines that were never sold in the US; a diesel or right-hand-drive 'first gen' is a gray import, not a US 4Runner.

NOTES

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